

User Research Plan: Cultured Mornings Portal

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Problem

(what the client/team has identified as the thing that needs to change)

Cultured Mornings is entering the third year of its pilot phase and is developing a Membership Portal intended to support alumni, workforce partners, and mentors. While the current website provides general program information, it does not yet offer a dedicated digital environment that:

- Represents alumni identities and lived experiences
- Facilitates mentorship and workforce engagement
- Supports long-term connection after age 18
- Provides access to learning resources and professional tools
- Helps workforce partners identify and engage emerging talent

There is a need to understand **what visitors feel is missing**, what they expect from such a portal, and what content, features, and storytelling would help them feel represented and supported.

Background

Cultured Mornings empowers youth to reach their full potential through food security, mentoring, skill-building, and community support. Alumni represent the next generation of culinary talent, community changemakers, and creative thinkers. As the organization grows, it needs a digital space that:

- Extends the warmth and hospitality of the in-person program
- Supports alumni in their transition to adulthood
- Provides workforce partners with direct access to talent
- Enables mentors to continue guiding students beyond the classroom

The Membership Portal will become a **central digital hub** embedded within the Cultured Mornings public website and launched by August next year.

Research Goal

(where we need to go)

To understand the needs, motivations, expectations, and behaviors of alumni, mentors, and workforce partners so we can design a Membership Portal that:

- Feels representative of who they are
- Reflects their goals, identities, and growth
- Helps alumni build and showcase portfolios
- Supports ongoing learning and mentorship
- Enables workforce engagement
- Extends community, connection, and belonging

Research Objectives

(how will we get there)

1. Understand how alumni transition from the program after age 18 and what ongoing support they need.
 2. Identify what information and features would help alumni feel represented and connected.
 3. Explore what mentors and workforce partners look for when evaluating alumni portfolios.
 4. Understand the expectations for digital mentorship, workforce pipelines, and professional visibility.
 5. Learn how users navigate the current website and where usability challenges exist.
 6. Assess the desirability of proposed features:
 - Real-time portfolio building
 - Workforce board access
 - Cooking tip videos
 - Virtual mentorship
 - Catering opportunities
 - Chef showcases
 7. Uncover gaps, frustrations, and unspoken needs
 8. Identify opportunities for a welcoming, community-driven digital experience rooted in Hospitality, Ujamaa, and Kuumba.
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Research Questions

(what we need to know to get there)

Alumni

1. What do alumni want access to after completing the program?
2. What does “representation” look and feel like for them online?
3. How do they currently build or think about professional portfolios?
4. What are their career goals and support needs?
5. What digital content (videos, showcases, resources) is most valuable?
6. What are their expectations for mentorship beyond graduation?
7. What challenges do they face when transitioning into adulthood or the workforce?
8. What barriers exist when interacting with the current website?

Mentors / Chefs / Educators

1. What information do mentors need to guide alumni virtually?
2. What moments of connection matter most in a mentorship relationship?
3. What would make the mentorship process easier or more impactful?
4. How should mentor-student matching be designed?

Workforce Partners

1. What do workforce partners look for when evaluating talent?
 2. What information do they need from an alumni portfolio?
 3. How do they currently find youth talent?
 4. What opportunities (volunteer, contract, full-time) do they want to offer?
 5. What would make them return to the portal?
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Methodologies

(how will we learn this)

1. User Interviews

To gather stories, expectations, barriers, and needs.

Interviews will follow IDEO's principles of:

- Building rapport
- Listening deeply
- Asking open, non-leading questions

2. Observational Usability Testing

To understand how users interact with the current Cultured Mornings website and what they cannot find, do not see, or feel is missing.

3. Comparative Research

Analyzing how other youth development, workforce, or alumni portals function, to understand norms and identify opportunities for innovation.

4. Surveys

Short surveys to gather demographic data, digital preferences, mentorship desires, and workforce needs.

5. Insight Synthesis

Insights will be grouped using IDEO's recommended sequence:

Capture → Cluster → Interpret → Share .

Participants

(which behavioral categories do we need to talk with to learn this)

Alumni (Primary Group)

- Ages 14-18+
- Recently completed or currently completing the program
- Interested in culinary arts, community service, catering, or creative careers
- Range of identities, backgrounds, and skill levels

Mentors / Chefs / Volunteers

- Current or past mentors
- Culinary professionals, chefs, educators
- Individuals active in mentorship or support roles

Workforce Partners

- Restaurants, caterers, food service organizations
- Community partners or culinary initiatives
- Employers seeking young talent

Cultured Mornings Team Input

To understand internal goals and constraints.

Assumptions/ Risk

(things that could put a kink in our research efforts, challenges... if there are any)

Assumptions

- Alumni desire deeper digital connection than the current website provides.
- Users want clear pathways to opportunities (mentorship, work, showcases).
- Workforce partners want streamlined access to talent.
- Alumni want to feel represented not only visually but narratively (tone, language, featured stories).

Risks

- Alumni may struggle to articulate what they want in a portal without examples.
 - Participants may give socially desirable answers rather than honest ones.
 - Workforce partners may have limited time for interviews.
 - Digital access and literacy may vary across alumni users.
 - Portal expectations may exceed technical feasibility or budget.
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